



Halt! Who goes there?



“Is this another step towards a controlled society? Are we willing to let someone else choose what content is appropriate for us?”

The police in Mumbai recently announced plans to make it mandatory for cyber cafe owners to demand proof of identification from anyone wanting to access the Internet from their establishments.

Did our future on the Internet just take a wrong turn? Are we perhaps seeing the beginning of a trend that will spread to other parts of the country? Or is this just another typical knee-jerk reaction to a situation that no one around here understands?

Consider the stated objectives. To bring under control various kinds of cyber crimes and to curb access to pornographic content.

But what is the point of this move?

Put aside for a second the completely justified concern you might have about your privacy being compromised. Keep in mind the fact that cyber crime is an issue we will need to grapple with sooner rather than later. It still isn't going to work. There are too many ways for people to get around this requirement. At the very least it's going to be completely ineffective.

The bigger danger is that people might become uncomfortable about using cyber cafes to access the Internet. Just at a time when Internet usage needs to be encouraged. Both government and industry are working to develop the potential of the Internet and cyber cafes, which provide inexpensive access to a large percentage of Internet users in India, have a critical role to play in this development process.

Consider also the matter of freedom of choice. Cyber cafe owners will now have to monitor and filter Internet usage. Is this another step towards a more controlled society? Are we willing to let someone else choose what content is appropriate for us? Must we disclose personal information to someone just because we need to access the Internet?

Is this freedom something that needs protecting in a democracy?

To effectively address cyber crimes, our police forces need to gain a better understanding of the tools used by the Internet criminal. It must be made mandatory for businesses to invest in protecting the interests of their customers. And greater synergy needs to be created between the industry and police agencies to tackle this very real menace.

A roadblock isn't usually the most effective way to catch a clever criminal, and it can often be disruptive. But it is usually the most obvious and visible solution to the problem.

Maybe that's exactly the point.

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